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complexity and which relate to the processes of human learning. We will examine the idea of experience as consciousness, biography, episode/event, expertise (skill and wisdom). I want to conclude with two other conceptual difficulties about experience.

Part 1: Experience as consciousness

Understanding learning from experience means that we look at a wide range of disciplines across the whole lifespan and learning cannot be understood in any other way since this is a human activity of which cognition is but one part. Chalmers (1996: 11–16) suggests that there are two forms of conscious experience:

- Phenomenological – the mind as conscious experience and as a consciously experienced mental state in which we feel in certain ways.
- Psychological – the mind as a causal basis of behaviour.

He regards these two approaches as close to each other since many kinds of psychological states can be associated with phenomenological states, and so on – but they do not coincide, and in some ways this distinction relates to the I–Me situation discussed previously and to which we will return towards the end of this book.

Soon after birth we do have experiences and we learn to memorise from sensations; Donald (2001: 75) suggests that memorising sensation is the basis of consciousness itself and that we learn consciousness as we learn and remember. But the significant thing about consciousness is that we need to be conscious of something – we need to experience external reality in some way. Consciousness is a bridge between the bare life within a human being (Agamben, 1995) – this is a concept that is even more basic than the idea that existentialists call Being – and external reality itself, but it needs external stimulation to generate awareness and also for it to remain stable. This latter fact was clearly demonstrated in an experiment at McGill University, which we described previously, in which some students were paid a financial reward to do nothing – in fact to be denied sensory perception for as long as they could. None lasted longer than three days before giving up, and even then some were temporarily mentally harmed: consciousness requires external stimuli – or experiences – in order to be consciousness. In other words, we need both people with whom to interact and the cultural experience that such interaction produces. We become ourselves in such a cultural environment: ultimately we are not individuals but individuals-in-groups and in social situations. This relationship is something of an entity in itself and, as we have already argued, following Buber (1958), that relationship is something with which we start life.

However, we may not be born with conscious awareness, as we all recognise when we see a newborn baby; we learn it by experience, and like its evolution, it grows and develops in each of us. Following Donald (2001: 178–200), there appear to be three evolutionary dimensions of consciousness:

- *Selective binding*. Binding is the process whereby we link together phenomena to produce a perceptual unity and it is only through consciousness that we can be aware of the external world.
- *Short-term memory*. This dimension follows from the previous one in as much as any binding requires a short-term memory in order to hold the whole together and, as the brain evolves, the focus changes from the binding mechanism to give the brain power to be free from the immediate context. In this freedom lies the capacity to develop human learning.

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- *Intermediate and long-term governance*. This builds on the previous two stages and expands the range of experience which forms the basis of our continued learning: it was during this stage of our evolution that the pre-frontal cortex and other regions of the tertiary cortex expanded, and this process occurred as a result of social interaction and the growth of culture.

It can thus be seen that consciousness itself has evolved through learning and remembering, and this same process is evident in our human development: it is the expanding brain that provides us with the opportunity of broadened experience from which we can continue to learn. Indeed, we are freed from the immediate experience and able to memorise past experiences. The basis of our learning is awareness itself – the act of experiencing – although it is attention that focuses our learning in a conscious manner. However, such conscious awareness is perhaps best recognised in language itself. When we can speak about an experience we are fully conscious of it, but once we actually speak about it we change its nature as Eliade (see Ricoeur, 1995: 48–55) explains, calling this phenomenon hierophantic when he writes about religious experience. I will return to this later in this chapter.

Bare life, then, is embodied and through the senses exposed to external stimuli, or *qualia*, which are processed through the brain. A more narrow use of this term *qualia* includes the idea of quality in sensory experience, such as colour, an approach that is favoured by some researchers (e.g. Rose, 2006), whereas others employ it more broadly to refer to all sensory experiences. However, the McGill experiment showed that we, humans, need much more than just consciousness to survive as normal human beings – we need experiences that are based in an external context about which we can become aware, or to which we can pay attention. This distinction is important – we are no doubt more aware of a wider context when we focus our attention, so that we can say that at one level we have an experience of the phenomenon to which we attend but we are often conscious of a wider reality. Consequently, there are degrees of awareness – some are at the heart of our concentration whereas others are at the periphery of our focus of attention, and in such skills as speed-reading we actually learn from our periphery as well as from the focus of our attention. From my own experience of getting people to write down their own learning experiences, it is clear that a great deal of learning in everyday life occurs at the periphery of our conscious awareness and even in our pre-consciousness. In these situations much of our knowledge is tacit. Our tacit knowledge is also reflected in a phenomenon that Marton and Booth (1997: 99–100) call appresentation, that is when we complete an incomplete experience by recalling knowledge that has been internalised without our full conscious awareness of it from an earlier experience.

Consciousness, however, spans all the levels of awareness, but it is expanded by language and ultimately by all other means of storing knowledge. What Crawford (2005) called attentive experiencing is significant here since it concentrates the mind on a specific phenomenon. In a sense, attentive experiencing is the type of awareness that occurs in in-depth thought, concentration or religious contemplation: in-depth learning that occurs as a result of our being more aware of the significance and content of that experience. The more that we attend to our experiences, the more we see in them and the more we learn from them: ‘paying attention’ is important to our conscious experience and is one of the most significant factors in learning. Significantly, in this rapidly moving world where people seem to have little time for anything a new movement is beginning – the slow movement (Honore, 2004) – which seeks to offer a challenge to the speed of the world and points us to the need for more attention to be given to the nature of experience. Thus, at one end of the spectrum we can have experiences of which we are not conscious because they happen so speedily but which require a further conscious experience to bring them to our conscious awareness, and at the other end of the spectrum we focus upon concentration, from which we gain a greater insight into our experience since we are more conscious of it and learn more from it.

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However, we are confronted at this stage with the work of Freud, who pointed us to the unconscious mind, and Polanyi (1967), who highlighted tacit knowledge, and by my own research into learning, in which I discuss the significance of the pre-conscious in learning. Indeed, we can actually now see how the pre-conscious experience occurs, which is important in our thinking both about perception and about learning. Goleman (1995: 17–20) reports on work by LeDoux (1996), who shows that:

> sensory signals from the ear and eye travel first in the brain to the thalamus and then – across a single synapse – to the amygdala; a second signal is routed to the neocortex – the thinking brain. This branching allows the amygdala to begin to respond *before* the neocortex which mulls information through several levels of brain circuits before it fully perceives and finally initiates a more finely tailored response.

Consequently, those early information signals allow a pre-conscious response to sensations and, therefore, we are enabled to have pre-conscious experiences that also lead to pre-conscious learning.

Recently, as I noted earlier, I detected a conceptual anomaly in my own work: in my definition of learning in Chapter 1, I included the phrase 'the perceived content of which', which implies that what gets into my mind is something of which I am aware – but I have also written about pre-conscious learning, which suggests that things get into my mind about which I am not aware. There is no doubt that we all have pre-conscious experiences which get imprinted, as it were, in the brain – when the bodily sensations are transmitted to the brain and the network of neurons reconfigured in some small or large way. But, conceptually, does learning stop at the point when we are not aware of the initial stimulus? From my own observations and experience, it seems that pre-conscious learning happens in two stages. We can experience events although we are not aware of every facet of what we have internalised, but the whole event has been experienced and stored in the brain pre-consciously. A subsequent experience acts as a stimulus, the response to which is to call to conscious awareness an aspect of a previous experience of which we had not been conscious before and from which we can now learn. This is the fuzzy boundary of experience and, therefore, the fuzzy boundary of learning, but the actual learning still requires conscious awareness although the experience from which we learn need not be conscious at the time when we experience it.

Experience, then, is wider than conscious awareness but it cannot be wider than being itself – but the pre-conscious is clearly a significant aspect of our biography.

Part 2: Experience as biography

In my own definition of learning, which was discussed in Chapter 1, I suggest that the outcome of every learning event is built into our biographies, although these need not only be our cognitions (see OECD, 2007a), as our definition makes clear. In this sense we are learned persons, but we see from the discussion in the first part of this chapter that memory itself has evolved and that memory itself frees us from the immediate experience and yet in a complex manner it is a working memory that enables us to recall past experiences as and when they become relevant. Consequently, when we exclaim: 'In all my experience …' we are really talking of all the learning events that have made us what we are at that moment in time. Biography is the sum of those experiences from which we have learned and we are the product of those experiences. It is no accident that the influential Faure Report (1972) was called *Learning to Be*.

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Our biographies are our understanding about ourselves as we pass through time. Time, however, forms a major problem when we consider experience; Rose (2006: 394) remarks that more 'needs to be done on this baffling problem' and we will look briefly at one aspect of this in the next part of this chapter. Relating time to consciousness Rose (ibid.: 394) says that all higher levels of consciousness are formed by binding between:

1 current input representations, short-term records and current motor efference (something that conducts outwards from the centre) to give retention or protention of the phenomenologists' 'thickness' of experience;
2 various durations of long-term memory … to generate conscious awareness of identity and meaning of a stimulus; and
3 long-term autobiographical memory and long-term plans, desires and life goals … our memories of the most significant evens so far, and imagined goals of what we want to reach in the future – to give us a sense of who we are and our sense of self.

Consequently, we can see that for as long as we are alive we are compiling our autobiography through experience and learning, and that we are always becoming (see Chapter 17) as we move from experience to experience or even from social status to social status. Phenomenology can be placed within this context since it is a process of 'binding across time to form systematic structures

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